while in-state tuition and fees at public national universities have grown the most, increasing 237 percent.

"To put those numbers into perspective," Emmie Martin wrote in a 2017 CNBC article, "a 1988 graduate of Harvard University would have spent $17,100 on tuition during their senior year. Now, in their 50s, they'd have to pay $44,990 in tuition for their child to attend Harvard today."

In 2011, when I was fresh out of college, the *Fiscal Times* reported that parents were depleting their nest eggs by paying their children's rent, food, and cell phone bills after graduation—all of this often on top of paying back loans. Because graduates are often in debt, more parents are also helping their kids buy their first homes, which is seen as an adult rite of passage. "Independent adulthood" can now mean being subsidized by your generous-to-their-own-detriment parents. Meanwhile those without parents who can subsidize it or without parents at all feel "less adult" for not being able to afford the trappings of adulthood.

This problem isn't affecting everyone equally. In 2016, *Forbes* reported that black, college-educated middle- to upper-class parents with more than one child with student debt are most often the ones paying back their children's loans. (Studies have also shown that black parents in the US are more invested in their children's educations because they know they'll need higher degrees to get the same positions and pay as white applicants. Ain't America great?)

John Brunson, a 30-year-old black bartender, is a good example of this. He attended the University of Central Arkansas to study communications and theater. He could make tuition work, but he needed loans to cover housing, books, and living costs. Brunson's father runs Central Arkansas Planning and Development, and his mom is a phlebotomist. Both of them went to school—his dad to college and his mom to training in her field. He said he and his dad talked only a little about loans, but both of his parents were *very* intent on college for him.

John decided to take out a personal loan from Sallie Mae and a federal loan. A student advisor (a version of a guidance counselor at his high school) told him she could find him all the loans he wanted. "Sign here, here, here, here and here," he joked. But John said she never explained any of the loans he was signing up